

DELHI | Contract Thriller

The Indian Air Force has begun flight tests and evaluation of the six contenders for the world's largest defence contract—a \$10 billion (Rs 48,000 crore) tender to buy 126 multi-role fighter aircraft. Six teams of IAF pilots will fly to Europe and the US to test and evaluate Boeing's F/A-18, Lockheed Martin's F-16, Sweden's Gripen, the Eurofighter Typhoon, France's Rafael and Russia's MiG-35. The field trials, which will end by the middle of next



year, are one of the most crucial aspects of the contest. The lowest bidder can no longer walk away with the contract. The IAF wants technology to be a key consideration of aircraft for the contract which will be signed by March 2011. *by Sandeep Unnithan*

THE IAF HAS OFFERED THE WORLD'S LARGEST DEFENCE CONTRACT WORTH \$10 BILLION TO BE SIGNED BY MARCH 2011.

DELHI | Auto Cut

The Delhi Government has finally decided to implement a decade-old rule of the Delhi Motor Vehicles Rules. Owners of public transport like autorickshaws, buses, taxis and trucks must now have authorisation permits carrying vehicle and driver particulars (from the Transport Department) given to their drivers. The key lies in executing the rule of course best exemplified by Delhi's Transport Department which hasn't given autorickshaw drivers new identity badges since October 2008.

by Nandini Vaish

RANCHI | Crore Issue

All hell has broken loose in the Madhu Koda camp in Jharkhand. The state Vigilance Bureau has filed FIRs against former chief minister Koda and five of his former ministers for "amassing disproportionate wealth". Ex-ministers Anosh Ekka and Harinarayan Rai are on the run from the police armed with non-bailable arrest warrants. The Ranchi Vigilance Court rejected Ekka's bail plea after the prosecution claimed that he owned assets worth Rs 4.5 crore though his declared earnings were only Rs 15 lakh. Koda himself is accused of siphoning off funds through hawala channels to Dubai and other countries.

by Amitabh Srivastava



AN INTRUSIVE TEST ON BRIDES-TO-BE HAS LANDED THE CHIEF MINISTER IN A SOUP

BHOPAL | Brides and Prejudice

The purported virginity test carried out on 152 brides-to-be in Shahdol district has landed Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan into a boiling pot of trouble. Vice General Secretary and former chief minister Digvijay Singh, leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Jamuna Devi, National Commission for Women Chairperson Girija Vyas and the Congress have dubbed the district administration's reported "virginity test" as an invasion of privacy of women. Following the test, 138 women were allowed to marry under the Government-sponsored Mukhyamantri Kanyadaan Yojana on June 30. Dr Reena Gautam, who conducted the tests, claims that they were in fact pregnancy tests. Big difference, doctor.

by Ambreesh Mishra



CHOUHAN WITH THE BRIDES AND GROOMS